

The Art of Dialogue in an Age of Communication

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The human being is a relational creature.

We are born into a bond — to a particular mother and family — and, as small and helpless creatures, we focus most of our efforts on forging connection and communication with the human other who envelops us. As we grow, our inner world expands, and begins to hold images and concepts of the sum of our experiences — that a ball falls when released, for example, or that a cold, plasticky sensation on the gums teaches us that this object is not edible — and among these, we develop a concept of the self. From a cognitive point of view, the concept of the self can be described as a "strange loop," in which I occupy both the role of the thinking subject and the role of the object of thought:[1] the self is my attempt to understand not my unmediated experience of the world, but rather the specific, particular way in which I act and respond to the world; the attempt to look at myself from without and understand something about this person, in a way similar to how I interpret and conceptualize everything outside me.

On this description, our awareness opens outward and only afterward turns inward. We relate to others first, and only afterward turn our instruments of relating toward ourselves, producing self-understanding and a sense of continuity and identity, also called "the self." The precedence of the "external" or the "other" over the "internal" or the "self" has many far-reaching implications; here I wish to focus on one particular angle — the firm presence of the human environment deep within our self-awareness, as a point of reference. In order to know ourselves — to understand who we are and to feel something toward what we are — we make use of relation and relativity, of comparison to our surroundings. A person is always engaged in a process of positioning, and builds his self-image through his relative position — of his character, deeds and attitudes — in comparison to the subjects who populate his actual environment, and thereby his consciousness. These subjects constitute the space of positioning, the "map" on which he anchors his identity.

In light of the existential centrality of this consciousness of relation, or of positioning oneself against one's human environment, shifts in the character of this environment, and of the interactions I conduct with it, can have far-reaching psychological and social consequences. In recent decades, such shifts have occurred every few years, bound up with new communication technologies that open our environmental horizon to new forms of

connection and to immense spaces. How do such technologies affect the shaping of the self and its positioning relative to its environment? In this essay I will examine the axis of a person's relation to his human environment from a point of view that sees it as a process of conversation. I will then examine the difficulties this axis of relation faces in light of the rise of the new media, and finally, I will propose religious language as a complementary axis of relation capable of healing these difficulties.

Relation as Dialogue

The process of self-positioning discussed above can be formulated as the ongoing conduct of a dialogue with the not-self. This dialogue, which bounds and defines the self, enables self-understanding and opens the door to all the complex feelings we have regarding the self — self-esteem, self-image, self-efficacy, and so on. Every judgment our consciousness is capable of making requires relativity, a reference point against which to compare; without these it is hard to grasp any concept at all, and certainly to express toward it a positive or negative feeling. The same holds for the self — in order to feel that I am good at something, or that I have a certain problem, I need to compare my state to some other, hypothetical state, a kind of "default," which I usually imagine on the basis of my familiarity with those around me. In order to understand what I believe, I need to understand what my parents or friends believe, and to wonder about the trust I place in their considerations and conclusions. The values I hold are taken from, and examined against, those found in my human environment. In general, discursive thought is sustained against the backdrop of a psychosocial context.

I use the term "dialogue," and no doubt some will read it as a kind of allegory for the reality of connection in general. But in fact, the metaphor of dialogue comes close to being a real description of the psychic occurrence being described, in which a person understands himself through relative positioning against the people he knows, or at least those significant to him for this purpose. As cognitive psychology teaches, our complex feelings — the building blocks of self-consciousness — are made up, to no small degree, of thoughts, beliefs and conceptualizations; and since these are mediated to us by language, language is also the medium of the process of self-positioning. And not incidentally: language is communicative in its very essence — a kind of corridor, open on one side to the content of our inner awareness, and, on the other, to the need to communicate outward from it. Accordingly, our conscious thoughts are always a kind of implicit dialogue with an imagined other.

A person's language does not develop within an "I-it" relation opposite the mute physical world and the experiences it brings him; he does not acquire it merely through a process of conceptual generalization and abstraction, like the development of some theory. A child acquires language solely through interpersonal interaction, out of the need to understand what the other is telling him, and by force of the wish to communicate his inner needs to the other. Because of this, our language always retains its communicative character, the possibility of communicating and conveying inner content, through it, to a human other, in

order to attain his understanding. When I formulate a thought to myself in words and sentences, even if it is a personal, intimate thought I have no intention of sharing with anyone, I am, in effect, preparing it for transmission; I build, organize and package it according to the rules of linguistic transmission that prevail among the people I converse with. In fact, this is the only way we experience understanding at all.

In other words, a person does not feel complex emotions toward his own self without passing through the estrangement of an outside point of view. Even if it seems that the actual other is not present in my thoughts about myself, the very fact that my thoughts are disclosed to me through the linguistic channel means that they also reflect the model I hold of my reference group — the people who share a common language with me (in the fullest sense of the term "common language"). My thoughts are formulated so as to fit my communicative space, and so as to carry content that can be understood, and even accepted, by whichever of my interlocutors, within the conversational context in which I live.

This is easy to illustrate through the semantics of degree adjectives. When I think to myself, "I am tall," "I am domineering," "I have a good musical ear" — even though these sentences contain no explicit comparison or relativity, the adjectives within them are unintelligible without a system of reference, such as what level of musical hearing counts as good as against less good. Such a statement places me on a continuum whose coordinates are set not by nature, but by the society and reference group I have implicitly turned to as this thought took shape within me.

But the penetration of the conversational context into the contents of our consciousness runs even deeper. Our conscious thoughts are also our way of weighing the paths before us, of adopting or changing positions, of shaping our lives; they are the building blocks of the freedom of our spirit. All of this occurs while the (internalized) human other stands before our eyes, even if unconsciously. It is before him that I converse with myself, and sometimes confront him directly; every rational procedure, every difficulty, argument, and justification, is validated for me by force of the discourse in which I take part. What I find acceptable is what I feel can be explained, can be understood — that is, what can be communicated between people.

This natural process, in which the voice of the other is present within me, and upon which I build my own thoughts, forms the basis of a wondrous and highly important human capacity, which I will call here — in keeping with the metaphor above — the dialogical capacity. The dialogical capacity is the ability to recognize and understand the place of the other, while, at the same time, identifying myself as distinct. In a broader formulation, this is a most basic capacity for the ongoing process of identity formation. The self is constituted through the "friction" created between it and the other: I identify myself by means of the difference that distinguishes and sets me apart from the picture I hold of the other. This process of separation-individuation[2] takes place in a linguistic context, as described above, insofar as I think about myself using words, concepts and a discursive system I share with my discourse community. My positioning within the social "map," across a range of subjects and dimensions, constitutes my identity against the background of distinction and

uniqueness from — as well as belonging and continuity with — the other familiar to me from my surroundings, my discourse community.

It seems, then, that the identity of this discourse community, or reference group, carries immense weight in shaping our inner world, and, specifically, in the development of the story we tell ourselves about ourselves. And then the internet came along and blew it apart.

The Explosion of the Reference Group

The eruption of media and the internet into our lives, at ever-growing levels of continuous exposure, has changed them in innumerable dimensions. We tend to think mostly about the technical aspects of this shift — how easy it is, say, to obtain some product cheaply from abroad, or to coordinate a meeting place with a friend — but we usually find it harder to dive into the deep and subtle meanings of this communications revolution for the inner fabric of our psychic and conscious life. In my view, the internet revolution takes on an important part of its full significance once we understand that even a human other whom we encounter through a screen and through written texts immediately becomes part of our human environment — that is, present within the dialogical space in which we converse with ourselves and understand ourselves. Thus, my reference group keeps stretching, and its function changes dramatically: instead of limiting my perspective to a small-to-medium social circle, something on the scale of a tribe or a village, whose overall picture I am able to grasp and from which I can derive a sense of self-understanding through relative positioning, the reference group of "the internet" is of an entirely different order of magnitude than anything we have grown accustomed to in human culture — vast and diverse to the point of being unable to be contained.

When almost all the people I am in contact with share many features of life, including beliefs, values and norms, it is easy for me to define myself in terms of the community I share with them, to justify my choices against the background of shared assumptions, and to distinguish myself at certain particular angles of life, in a way that helps me feel that I bring a unique color and voice into the world. This is the fabric of life in which human beings, almost all of them, lived until quite recently in historical terms. Since the onset of the modern era, a series of processes and inventions — among them print, urbanization, transportation and the means of communication — have expanded and loosened our social networks. If I have a convenient way of staying in touch with a friend who lives in another country — whether thanks to fast travel, efficient mail, or digital means of communication — I am, in effect, living in a world where distances are mentally shorter, even if the physical distance remains; and accordingly, more and more kinds of people, groups and "discourse communities" enter into the range of my awareness and consciousness. My ability to account for my place within the enormous, tangled network that keeps accumulating diminishes, and I find it hard to conduct a dialogue with my "environment"; this environment threatens to crush my identity beneath the massive multiplicity of human identities it contains, to erase my distinctiveness.

There is, I admit, an element of exaggeration in the description above. One can certainly raise a simple objection against it — namely, that the reference group derived from "the internet" as a whole is not existentially relevant to anyone, since no person browses the entire internet or meets all the communities and people reachable through the online space. The average person perhaps reaches, with the help of the network, one or two steps further than he could have reached in the offline world, and at times will reach even further than that, but most residents of Israel, for example, do not browse Chinese, Norwegian or Brazilian websites, and do not converse with random people from Africa on a daily basis. Moreover, if in the early years of the internet a kind of super-nodes or hubs formed — like forums or news sites, where masses of people gathered and were suddenly fused into a single discourse community, in the literal sense — then from the era of social networks onward, the direction has actually been a diligent retreat into the circle of the familiar and the similar. Today these networks apparently narrow our circle of relation back to its local, traditional dimensions, and perhaps even to narrower dimensions still.

That said, a purely behavioral look at the communicative distances people travel daily in their network behavior, and the conclusion that most of them remain within the local domain, misses a very significant aspect of the internet experience and of the way it shapes our consciousness. For when dealing with media, we have learned that "the medium is the message" — that is, that the communicative channel, the form and features of the instrument through which the message is transmitted or received, is present in the existential experience no less than the content and the addressee of the transmission. In our context, the important fact is that, experientially, in terms of (the absence of) waiting time, the transmission-distance from me to the blog of a priest in a Dominican church in South Africa is the same distance as from me to the blog of the local commentator I admire. This fact instills in us the recognition that even communication with local circles via the internet is an elective act of narrowing, a choice that takes hold of a certain interlocutor and disregards other interlocutors. I am still capable of looking only at the members of my close circle, but I cannot help but see, past the edge of my focus, all the countless circles from which I avert my eyes. And as an elective act, our secondary gaze must give an account of itself; the faint awareness of it perforates the rigidity of the particular boundaries it sets, and leaves behind some measure of the reality of the possibilities I did not choose. In other words, there are parts of my consciousness that continue to carry on a dialogue with all the sites I do not browse — a more conscious awareness with regard to sites I know of and consciously do not browse, and a less conscious awareness with regard to sites I do not yet know of (but know of the possibility of knowing — for the gates of Google have not been locked).

In this sense I think that the internet medium, and its amplified presence in our daily communicative experience, are shaping within us a new cognitive reality; a close relative, if you will, of the cognitive reality that gave rise to postmodern relativistic thought on the philosophical plane. In this reality I am forced to position myself against ever-expanding circles of human beings, groups and individuals, and my conversation with the other-self —

the one I need in order to understand myself — becomes crowded to the point of suffocation.

A Life Steeped in Communication

Beyond the stretching of the reference group, and the entry of an overwhelming human multiplicity into the short blanket of consciousness that seeks to attend to all these voices and to conduct a dialogue with them — and struggles to do so because of its inherent limitations — the new communication technologies also amplify, unprecedentedly, the availability of discourse, and the presence of one's interlocutors. Even if we deal only with communication with our local circles — the national, sectoral and local community — the conversation itself becomes far more present and prominent in our lives. The quantity of interactions with a human other that our consciousness sustains in a single day is immeasurably greater than what our parents were accustomed to. The world surrounds us with a bombardment of verbal messages, dramatized, written or heard, from radio and television, through app notifications, down to the text we read against our will off the cereal box sitting in front of us at breakfast. But beyond this, most of us belong to a large number of communication groups or communication platforms — WhatsApp, Facebook, email — whose active conversation almost never falls silent, and is always accessible to us with the raise of a thumb.

Most of us do not necessarily take an "active" part in so many communication activities around the clock, but even seemingly "passive" reading carries our consciousness into the territories of conversation and activates our dialogical capacity. For even if we do not respond, we imagine what we would answer, or what we say to ourselves; and even if the subject does not capture our interest, it captures our attention for that time, and populates our awareness with new musings and content. Words hover around us all day long. We have always been social, communicative creatures, and modern man, in certain contexts, may even find himself alone for more hours than in previous eras. But the constant presence of chatter and discourse with a broad social circle, like an endless cocktail party, is a new phenomenon. It seems this can have serious consequences for our mental ability to conduct genuine discourse with the other, and perhaps even to hear ourselves.[3]

Interim Summary

Let me summarize the course of the argument thus far.

A person weaves his identity and self-understanding through an internal "conversation" with the human circles in his environment. The ability to grasp the multiplicity of human positions, while, at the same time, sustaining an independent identity distinct from these positions through inner-conscious discourse — an ability we have called the dialogical capacity — may be undermined in the internet age, out of flooding and exhaustion. This is due to two distinctive features of life in this era — first, the expansion and "explosion" of our consciousness's reference group, that is, the exposure and access to a diverse, even chaotic, human mass, and its transformation into a close human "environment" against

which my inner dialogue does, or is meant to, take place; and second, the dramatic presence of communication, of interpersonal and social conversation in its external-real sense, within the technological fabric of life.

Can one point to an expression of this exhaustion of the dialogical capacity in our society?

In the following paragraphs I will argue that the answer to this is affirmative. I will try to show that this exhaustion allows us to connect the escalation of communication technologies to several broad and troubling social phenomena. I will then point toward a direction of solution: I will turn to religious and existential lines of thought that place the dialogical religious experience at their center, and I will argue that in the proper religious stance before God there is healing and rescue from the flood of internet discourse.

The Polarization of Discourse

For anyone who spends time on social networks — almost everyone, in the society in which I live — it is hard not to get the sense that public discourse is escalating and becoming more polarized. Something in the melody of the common messages crossing the network broadcasts a basic social rift, a sharp split between two groups, cultural or ideological, and establishes a tendency to derive your starting point in public debate — if not your positions themselves — from your binary affiliation. It seems as though some watershed line has suddenly burst forth and split society in two, and this division seemingly explains all the disagreements and all the value conflicts that exist within it. Whoever approaches public discourse discovers that instead of flexible, shifting coalitions, substantive and moderate arguments, and complex ideological positions, his toolbox contains only two signs reading "for" and "against."

A number of studies point to a connection between social and ideological polarization and the algorithms that shape social networks. Sites like Facebook or Twitter, for example, prefer to show their users posts that, based on their social circle, are likely to please them and that they will tend to agree with. When certain content does manage to cross the boundary between camps, it is often because someone from "my" circle chooses to share a post from "theirs" in order to illustrate the absurdity, shock, and alienation such content is meant to arouse "in us." [4]

That said, it seems to me that the development of social networks, and the intensification of the confirmation bias they engender, are themselves the product of a broader psychological response to the communications and internet revolution. The circle before which I account for myself is no longer bounded by my actual environment; my reference group is no longer the natural one, defined and delimited by the circumstances of my local life, but rather an infinite, ever-stretching group of people, groups and identities. There are positive sides to this expansion as well — we are exposed to the beauty of human diversity, to the breadth of spiritual richness from all the world's treasures. But alongside this, our ability to stand before this chaotic wealth and conduct a conversation — to understand ourselves as standing opposite and in relation to it — remains fairly limited. And so, because this

challenge is so difficult, and beyond our measure, we contract the muscles of our dialogue, and, in one way or another, "pull down the screen."

The most accessible way for our consciousness to overcome diversity is to classify it — "whoever is not with us is against us." In order not to have to conduct a genuine conversation with so many kinds of others, different from me in various directions, and in order not to get stuck in the wondering, doubt and confusion that genuine dialogue affords, I perform a reduction of the multidimensional social field to a single dimension. On this reduced plane, not only does the "other," found in my outgroup, become a flat cutout unworthy of conversation — something already common in the tribal circumstances natural to us — but I also perceive the members of my ingroup in a less deep way. I attribute the main weight of my ingroup members' presence to the very fact of their belonging to the group, to the fact that they are supposed to agree with me. I do speak within a "filter bubble" in which everyone thinks more or less like me, but, unlike the boundaries of a natural environment, the bubble's walls are only semi-opaque; the conversation within it is conducted, to a great degree, against and in relation to what is happening outside it. Being on the defensive or on the offensive — states of discourse so common today — rules out dialogue altogether, since dialogue requires the strength to go out to meet the other's point of view, to appropriate it into your own inner voice, and only then to differentiate yourself from it through argument, in order to reconstitute yourself as an independent point of view.

The Return of the Taboo

Closely related to the processes of binarization and polarization, the exhaustion of the dialogical capacity finds an almost symbolic realization in a further feature of contemporary discourse: the power struggle over the boundaries of discourse. It seems that, compared to the past, far more energy is invested today in defining, declaring and codifying "what may not be said." From one direction, there is a rise in norms of "political correctness," and a constant expansion of what falls under the taboo of concepts and positions declared closed military zones by many of those who hold the keys to institutionalized public discourse. From another direction, it seems that the intensification of tribalism and polarization described in the previous paragraph brings with it a stronger "bon ton" within every group or discourse community, both on the right and on the left, such that in almost no context is it "permitted" to say things that sound too similar to the positions of the community's rivals. From every side, it seems increasingly common to feel that a gag order has been placed upon you.

It seems to me easy to understand, on the sociological level, the correlation of these trends specifically with pluralistic multiplicity of opinion, or, as some would say, with the postmodern condition of the collapse of institutional monopolies on truth. Precisely because "there is no single truth" — that is, because trust has weakened in the existence of unambiguous, objective foundations for the clarification of this or that rational truth, foundations that could serve as a productive basis for clarifying truth through confrontation and disagreement — people and communities are forced to seek other mechanisms or rules

of thumb that will reduce the burden of opinions that must be taken into account in order to form a position.

Without excluding explanations of this kind at all, I think it useful to conceptualize and explain this correlation also on the level of psychological description, by looking at intrapersonal dynamics. Our capacity to stand head-on in confrontation with an opinion we find hard to accept, to argue face to face, is a mental resource that can be trained like a muscle, but can also be worn out and have its strength depleted. The basic recognition that there is an overwhelming diversity of opinions, when it becomes so existential, so piercing and so everyday, actually exhausts pluralism in its value-based sense. In this sense, binarization is not always sufficient; we require a further, more primitive mechanism, for expelling foreign voices we find hard to accept from our consciousness — and so we turn to silencing. We erect artificial partitions at the boundaries of truth's domain, both before ourselves and before others, as if to say — only here is it even worth looking for something, this is the game board, and whatever lies outside it is not worth the effort, is not worthy of being heard, and certainly not of holding a conversation with; you are required only to remain silent toward it. The social codification that occurs on the plane of real conversation rolls over into the silencing of the inner conversation I instinctively conduct with the representations of the other within my consciousness, into an unwillingness to let another voice in, to ponder it, to grapple with it, and only then to sift out its chaff.

Fundamentalism as the Freezing of Discourse

On a broader plane, I find that the exhaustion of the dialogical capacity gives rise to a certain manner of holding beliefs and opinions, a manner that has become more common in broad segments of modern societies, and in the religious context in particular. The rise of fundamentalism — a term describing a simple but zealous faith in the foundations of traditional religious belief, and a position advocating the immediate application of the plain-sense implications of scripture and sources — is usually explained as a reaction to the collapse of religious authority in modern society, on the one hand, and to the failure of the rationalist-secular philosophical project, on the other. After being disappointed by the optimistic promises of Enlightenment ideology — apparently under the influence of the events of the twentieth century — modern society was left without supports for a stable foundation of its worldview, since neither the religious faith and tradition long since abandoned, nor human-rational inquiry and consensus, are able to bear the burden. While most of secular society gave up its hubris and pretension and remained with a softer, more agnostic secularism, parts of this society — together with parts of religious society — returned to religion as an anchor, and sought to receive from it, once again, the validity and certainty it granted its believers before modernity.

Although fundamentalism advocates a "return" to the religious condition, to the sacred past, and to the actualization, in the present, of ancient traditions as literally written, it is important to note that it does not actually reconstruct this past, but rather constitutes a new position that is the result of a crisis. The sacred religious past is a world in which religion is

the "self-evident," the only possibility on the horizon. The modern condition is the reverse, and so even one who wishes with all his heart to return to this past already finds himself in a different world, one in which the "innocent" religious option is absent. The fundamentalist believer holds his beliefs against a secular majority society, against and despite the opposing worldviews that dominate most of the mechanisms of the society in which he lives — the state, the law, the economy, science, technology, psychology, and so on. Against his will, he holds fast to religion as opposition to secularism. Because of this, the sociologist will explain, in order to mark and consolidate this opposing stance, the fundamentalist movement hardens its positions relative to what was actually accepted in the real religious past, adopts the more zealous approaches and the more extreme positions within the religious field, and flattens the original dimensions of complexity that characterized the living religion.

I find logic in this reactive explanation, but here too, in my view, an explanation on the level of psychological description will help us sketch a richer and clearer picture of fundamentalism.

The thread running through the fundamentalist conception and experience is the avoidance of discourse. The fundamentalist leaps into religious faith, and declares that faith is not based on a discursive weighing of evidence and inferences, since these cannot bring about the absolute certainty with which faith is crowned. In doing so he frees himself from the need, and also from the possibility, of grappling with doubts within his faith, with heretical thoughts, and with the many secular ideas blowing through the world's atmosphere. This is a response of turning one's back, of neutralizing dialogue with everything outside the circle of faith. In the space between the intra-faith and the extra-faith realms there reigns silence, but this is not the silence of listening or of what lies beyond speech, but a frozen, anti-discursive silence.[5]

Beyond the general modern context, it seems one can find an intensification of fundamentalism in modern societies in the past decade, and I think the correct context for describing this process is the media revolution and the entry into a new digital-communicative age. If, in the pre-internet world, the fundamentalist could settle into his local community, devote himself to the principles of his religion, and remove from his heart the cultural and ideological confrontation lodged at the heart of his faith-based picture of the world, then in the networked and connected world in which he lives today, such a possibility requires a far more deliberate and conscious effort. The confrontation with the extra-religious other, the conversation with him, and the media through which this conversation takes place, surround us and circle around us constantly. These — to the extent that they are allowed in — place a burden on the "muscles of self-justification" of religious faith, to the point that it prefers to survive by keeping them out. We are saturated by the voice of the other, and in order to silence this voice, which stirs ferment within us, a strong, perhaps even violent, act of consciousness — an act of silencing — is required.

But the silence does not stop at the threshold of the church, the mosque, or the study hall. Fundamentalism gathers within the courtyard of religion, but when this courtyard is

fortified behind high walls, religion itself, too, is cast into shadow. A religion on the defensive cannot sustain the dynamic, adaptive and vital character it possessed when it lived independently within the world of ideas. Hence, fundamentalism changes the religious character in a fundamental way, as expressed in its attitude toward the ancient, sacred sources. As noted, fundamentalism is characterized by a stubborn adherence to a literal reading specifically of scripture, a reading characterized by the abandonment of the interpretive positions and methodologies produced by the later living tradition of that religion, and by the uprooting of the mechanisms that created a gap between the plain sense of the sources and their immediate application, in practice, to a new reality. In Judaism, which holds a foundational conception of a separation between the "Written Torah" and the "Oral Torah," and grants practical priority to the latter — as expressed in the words concerning "the judge who shall be in those days" — this turning away from the need for interpretation takes on secondary significance.

It seems that fundamentalists' difficulty with a layered, historical religious world, at whose foundation lies the duality of source and interpretation, is connected to their difficulty in conducting dialogue. For what is the process of religious interpretation, if not a broad conversation, with many participants, at one end of which stands divine revelation, in the middle the traditional sources of interpretations and interpretations of interpretations, and at the opposite end — the student himself, a person of this time, who tries to make his ear a funnel and hear what God is speaking to him in the place and time in which he stands? The sources do not impose themselves upon reality; the way to bring them into actuality passes through the learning person, through his consciousness, through the fusion he performs within himself between old and new, between the divine and the human, between the heavenly and the earthly. The transmission of the Torah from generation to generation takes place by means of this inner conversation of each generation with the generation that preceded it, of the scholar with the text and with the interpretations already given upon it. In this conversation something real occurs — a communicative bridge is formed between the sides. Since the fundamentalist holding of religion involves a freezing of the ability to conduct dialogue with the extra-religious other, the dialogical capacity as a whole atrophies, and the frozen silence takes over the intra-religious space as well.[6] In other words, fundamentalism is, to a great degree, a sealing-off of discourse. If I am not willing to negotiate with the foreign voices I hear even within my own inner conscious world, then the ability to engage dialogically with revelation itself is also blocked, and I try to erase myself beneath religious doctrine and command. Moreover, since I am not even willing to acknowledge that there are voices from without within me, I ultimately become estranged from every voice that echoes within me. If so, the silence begins in relation to the surrounding extra-religious world, is copied onto the intra-religious interpretive plane, and finally rolls over into an inner silence toward oneself, an inner alienation.

Religiosity as Dialogue

I have thus surveyed several troubling social phenomena, and proposed that they are connected to the difficulties the internet age and the new media pose for our dialogical

capacity — difficulties stemming, as described in the earlier chapters, both from the expansion, to the point of "explosion," of our reference group, the addressee of our inner dialogue, and from the saturated presence of communication in our daily lives. In the chapters that follow, which close the essay, I will point to the possibility that religious life, in its healthy Jewish form, offers a person healing and repair for these difficulties.

Judaism is an intensive course in the development of the dialogical capacity.

At the center of religious life in light of Judaism stands the standing before God — "Walk before Me" (Gen. 17:1). This standing has many shades. It has an aspect of submission, awe and the acceptance of the yoke of the kingdom; it has an aspect of longing, yearning and devotion (*deveikut*); it has a dimension of gratitude, of admiration and praise, of wonder and flight, of astonishment and dread. But what is common to all of these is the very "confrontation," the standing before God, as an experience constituting the foundation of existence. In the Genesis narrative, man is created and immediately becomes God's interlocutor, who blesses him, guides him and commands him. In this, God, in effect, gives man speech, having created him with a unique communicative capacity —

And He breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and man became a speaking spirit.

Targum Onkelos, Genesis 2:7

And out of the ground the LORD God formed every beast of the field and every bird of the heavens, and brought them to the man to see what he would call them; and whatever the man called each living creature, that was its name.

Genesis 2:19

By force of the divine turning toward him, man turns his gaze upward and stands for judgment and dialogue before the King of the universe. This is not merely a bowing before a king of justice who brings our deeds to judgment, but a space of manifold relation — as a merciful father, as a loving and beloved companion, and as a wise Creator to whom one must give thanks for all the splendor of nature. Every shade of standing before God ultimately translates, beyond the character of the emotional experience, into a certain kind of dialogue with Him — a dialogue that becomes an inseparable part of the soundtrack of life.

The religious person does not stand before God only at the time of prayer, or while performing a ritual ceremony. In one respect, the servant of God lives out of a consciousness that seeks to do what is upright and proper in the eyes of his God, and he converses both with his conscience and with the Torah, tradition and *halakha*, in order to clarify and understand what the correct deed is. In another respect, he longs to behold, in his actual life, the manifestations of God, to bless Him for the good and take shelter in His shadow in time of trouble, to give thanks for His having breathed life into his nostrils, and even to rise up against Him over a reality of injustice. In this he carries the dialogue with him at every step and turn of his life. Some will seek to cleave to the Holy One in all their ways by "raising up sparks" and serving Him through the material, and some will fulfill "know Him in all your

ways" by aligning the direction of their intent toward Heaven in every single deed. Either way, Jewish religious life is full of the knowledge of God as an act bearing a dialogical relation, an act of constant inner conversation with a God who has turned His face toward me and asked that I speak with Him, and about Him, all my days — "And you shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your might. And these words, which I command you this day, shall be upon your heart... and you shall speak of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise up" (Deut. 6:5–7).

The religious dialogue is special in that it is a hierarchical dialogue; man and God do not stand as equals upon a single plane, but rather God is the one who turns, the first, the primary and the supreme, and man is the one addressed, commanded, created and answering. This hierarchical dialogue that God conducts with His creatures through religious life instills in man a developed dialogical capacity, beyond what "ordinary" life, devoid of a religious point of reference, grants a person by force of the equal, social dialogues he conducts with his human environment. In fact, man cannot withdraw from the religious conversation, since God commands him whether he wills it or not, and man must listen in order to obey; alongside this, God also reveals Himself in a manner that requires active listening and participation in understanding and shaping the command. The command is encoded in the divine speech of the original revelation, in the interpretations given to it across the generations, and even in autonomous reasoning; in almost every practical step of actual life, deciphering it will require both a listening ear and an understanding heart to decide between clashing values/commands and between the essential and the secondary. Man cannot truly withdraw into frozen silence; God indeed speaks to him, but he must draw out from within it the practical content of this divine speech in a given situation. On the face of it this is a process of interpretation alone, but in fact it necessarily involves one's inner values and inner conception of what is proper, correct and important. At the same time, because of the hierarchy, the distinction remains sharp — I am not identical to what I am commanded, my will is not one with the divine will, and a whole range of responses can be aroused within me in the face of the command.

In other words, the "confrontation" with the religious command in particular, and with the divine reality in general, forces the admission of a foreign voice, along with an inner and deep confrontation with it, and self-definition against it.[7] As will be recalled, this is precisely how we defined the functioning of the dialogical capacity in the social context. Therefore, religious life — to the extent that standing before God occupies a central part of its being — constitutes an ongoing exercise of the dialogical "muscle"; it strengthens a person's ability to conduct, within his consciousness, intensive discourse with an other, while, at the same time, standing in his own distinctiveness against him. It follows that a person trained in religious dialogue is better equipped to face the challenges the modern, ultra-communicative environment poses to his dialogical capacity.

Horizontal versus Vertical Dialogue

If we take one further step, it seems that the religious answer to the difficulties arising in I-other relations in an ultra-communicative world goes one level deeper than what we have described. For standing before God is not merely a practice or "exercise" of a dialogical muscle that a person also employs when he comes to the social field; more importantly, it presents a new dimension of relation — vertical as opposed to horizontal — whose very existence changes the picture.

The religious experience, at least at its inner core, is an a-social experience; a kind of monad in which only God and man are present, and everything else is stage-setting in the drama unfolding between them. God seeks out the individual person, speaks to him and commands him in direct address. As a result, the religious person standing before God finds a further addressee for the inner conversation he conducts with himself. He judges his deeds, for instance, from the point of view of the will of God, seeks the traces of providence, or asks himself whether God believes in the sincerity of his feelings. In short, he conducts with God a continuous, daily and intimate dialogue, and defines an essential part of his identity through this vertical dialogue, to which only the two partners are privy.[8] In this, standing before God constitutes a new linguistic-dialogical space in which the self can speak to itself and become clear to itself, without passing through the social channel.

In light of this, let us return to the problem of the explosion of the discourse community. My claim is that, by also holding a vertical axis of relation, the religious person gains a different perspective on himself, one that does not require that same discourse community, and is therefore unaffected by its stretching beyond the bounds of conscious containment. Hence, although the horizontal expansion of my human discourse community makes self-understanding and identity-formation more difficult for me, it does not collapse the entire self beneath it; there still remains within me a space that is not relative-social or culture-dependent, but absolute and individual.

Let us illustrate this a little. Often, a person seeks to feel that his life is meaningful by thinking about the human circles he influences. For example, someone with children is filled with a sense of meaning from understanding how vital his presence is to them. Every person wants to feel that someone loves or needs him, and, beyond that, he also wants to feel that his life and his actions leave a mark on the lives of as many people as possible. Here too, thinking about circles of influence, and even the conscious attempt to somehow "quantify" the breadth of my influence and the mark I leave, are entirely bound up with my reference group, with the human environment accessible to my consciousness. It seems that growing exposure to the immense breadth of human circles in which I have no part — the understanding that, for the lives of billions of people in the world, my existence has no influence at all — casts a shadow over the sense of meaning that was much easier for me to derive when only my actual environment stood before my eyes. But here the vertical-religious perspective on my life arrives, and offers my quest for meaning an alternative that rests on no human circle around me — a channel of meaning found in the sublime service of God. Instead of trying to hold on to worldly consciousness, religion allows one to hold on to the eternal itself, through a life of dialogical standing before God.[9]

In a somewhat different way, in the face of the incomprehensible breadth of the human world, it is not only the meaning of my life that is weakened, but also my sense of self-worth. When only the members of my tribe stood before me, I was able to see my own salient advantages, my unique personal skills, my special place in the social fabric. But when the internet floods my eyes with all the talented people from every corner of the population, a great faintness of spirit strikes. Against a background of colors so saturated with success and talent, my own abilities grow grey, and my sense of worth cracks. Here too, the religious perspective repaints the importance and worth of a person — "every person is obligated to say, the world was created for my sake." The very fact that God turns to man and considers his service a matter worth attending to grants him a fathomless and absolute importance, one not derived from any interpersonal comparison on the horizontal axis.

In a similar way, the second problem we pointed to above — the intensified and dramatic presence of social-human discourse as a result of the exponential advance of communication technologies — also becomes lighter in light of the existence of dialogue on the vertical dimension. The religious approach, which grants trust and reality to the existence of a divine perspective on my life, sweetens the condition of a person who is growing deaf from the noise of the countless conversations he is forced to take part in. For all this social discourse, this entire horizontal level, is only one level on which I live, and I need not give it my whole heart. Because of this, I regain the freedom to decide how much energy I invest in this horizontal type of discourse. I will still be caught up in ongoing conversation and a constant process of positioning, but they will not shake the ground beneath me, since I do not position myself only as standing on the ground, shoulder to shoulder with the other, but also as standing alone before the face of heaven.

On both these fronts, the remedy is that, opposite the social permeability that characterizes natural man — to the point that even his thoughts, values and aspirations are formulated within the patterns of discourse that the society around him provides for him — there stands, in full force, a wondrous and deep bond with the Absolute. This vertical bond causes interpersonal relation — such as the question of social positioning with which we opened — to matter less to me for the purpose of defining, understanding and directing myself. I do not relate to myself as a vanishing point on a plane, but as an individual standing on his own, in "vertical" coupledness with the One and Only of the world. If we return to the basic metaphor we have used throughout this essay for the workings of consciousness — dialogue — one can say that the conversation with God opens a channel of communication parallel to the one I instinctively conduct with my human environment, and whoever is admitted into its secret is able to speak with himself and understand himself even when it becomes difficult to encompass and grasp the social horizon spread before him.[10]

Closing

In sum, the self is born out of a bond of communication with its environment, which we have called dialogue. Communication technologies alter our environment of relation and place a burden on the dialogical capacity, something expressed both in the polarization and

regulation of the boundaries of social discourse, and in the rigid blocking of the inner speech that echoes the voice of the other, in the fundamentalist context. Standing before God can heal the difficulties of the exhaustion of the dialogical capacity, since the inner dialogue with God constitutes a constant exercise of the ability to "be penetrated" by the voice of the other, while, at the same time, standing against it and developing an inner voice that sustains discourse with it. Beyond this, the vertical-religious bond constitutes an alternative relational-dialogical addressee, an alternative source of identity and self-understanding that weakens the dependence on conversation with, and positioning against, the human other. It therefore supplies a framework of life within which the explosion of the reference group and the communicative burden do not dismantle the ability to conduct dialogue and to build the self through it.

The conclusion here regarding the contribution of the vertical axis of life is part of a broader thought, one valid not only in the dialogical context we have discussed in this essay.

Through our engagement with the need, or the necessity, of conducting an inner conversation with an other in order to sustain some measure of reflection, we have sought to illuminate how a world possessing a heavenly dimension, added to the flat social-earthly dimension, opens up new possibilities of freedom for a person. Just as God's turning toward the world enables a breach of the laws of nature and politics, as revealed in the exodus of the children of Israel from Egypt, so too His turning toward man endows him with new horizons and rescues him from a limited, closed natural existence, and from the dependencies bound up with it — "for they are My servants, whom I brought forth out of the land of Egypt"[11] — and not servants to servants.

* * *

Notes

1. See: Douglas Hofstadter, *I Am a Strange Loop*, Basic Books, 2007.

2. The term "separation-individuation" is taken from the developmental-psychological theory of Margaret Mahler, where it describes the process by which the infant moves from a state of symbiosis and non-separateness from his mother (or from nature as a whole) to a reality of a distinct and independent personality. Here I use it with a certain license, to point to an ever-ongoing process of self-identification and self-understanding through separation from the other, not necessarily in the developmental context.

3. Between the lines, I am here dropping a hint toward the phenomenon known in cognitive psychology as the "cocktail party effect," according to which a healthy person is able to direct his attention to particular stimuli important to him and filter out background noise even in a crowded and noisy environment — like people at a packed cocktail party who manage to hold a conversation, or even to hear their own first name spoken across the room. In a later study, Narayan and colleagues found that background noise that is too numerous and too complex blocks, past a certain threshold, this ability to sustain attention (Narayan, Rajiv; Best, Virginia; Ozmeral, Erol; McClaine, Elizabeth; Dent, Michael; Shinn-Cunningham, Barbara; Sen, Kamal (2007). "Cortical interference effects in the cocktail party problem." *Nature Neuroscience*. 10(12): 1601–1607. doi:10.1038/nn2009).

4. Indeed, as a national community that participates massively in social networks, Israel found itself, recently (in the years 2019–2021), in an unprecedented political paralysis, owing to an inability to form a coalition agreement able to command a majority, and it seems easy to see how the polarization of public discourse — alongside other factors, of course — lies behind this democratic failure.

5. In Torah 64 of Likkutei Moharan, Rabbi Nachman of Breslov deals with the attitude toward different kinds of heresy; regarding the "hard" heresy — which he defines as questioning faith with "difficulties arising from the empty space" (chalal ha-panui), difficulties that have no answer — one must cope by way of a display of silence: "For these confusions and difficulties of this heresy, which come from the empty space, are of the aspect of silence [...] and one must simply believe and be silent there [...]." Contemporary Breslov Hasidism interprets this silence as a dogmatic flight from any inquiry or casting of doubt on simple faith, and it seems that Rabbi Nachman indeed wanted his listener-followers to interpret it this way; but at the same time he leaves in his words a trail leading to a different understanding of the essence of this silence: "And therefore it is forbidden to enter into and examine the words of this heresy and these confusions, except for a tzaddik who is of the aspect of Moses, for Moses is of the aspect of silence, in the sense of being called 'heavy of mouth' (kaved peh), the aspect of silence that is above speech; and therefore the tzaddik [...] can examine the words of these confusions, which are, as said, of the aspect of silence, and indeed must examine them, in order to raise up the souls that fell there, as above."

6. There is no doubt that the alternative religious position as well — one that opposes fundamentalism and seeks to cling to the traditional process of interpretation — faces significant difficulties. In the end, modernity is a crisis-reality after which nothing can continue as it was, and even the attempt to resemble the world that once was, in terms of dynamic interpretation and the spontaneous communal shaping of religious ways of life, runs into a wall that severs it from traditional continuity, and forces it to recognize that its own religious experience, too, is a modern invention, and, to a great degree, a gamble made in the dark. But this is not the place for that.

7. Many non-religious people tend to grasp religious life in a different, anti-dialogical way, one involving self-silencing and self-nullification before a dictating and dominating religion. As noted in the previous chapter, this conception also echoes at the margins of the religious world itself, in the form of fundamentalism. But in my view, the royal road of religious life, as experienced by the mainstream currents of Judaism, is described far more accurately by the dialogical reading I have proposed above, among other things because of the central place the Torah grants human reason and the wisdom of the heart in producing the practical determination out of the "encoded" revelation.

8. Of course, on a more sober and complex view, the human-social plane also penetrates the intimate religious discourse a person conducts with his God, and the religious relationship is greatly influenced by the theological and religious (and, of course, ideological and halakhic) worldviews prevalent in the religious person's human environment. But this does not detract from the picture we have drawn, since from the point of view of that individual's own consciousness, the religious space is indeed solipsistic and intimate, and does not involve relating to this or that group of people, in direct correspondence with their positions and their discourse.

9. Moreover, from that same "divine" point of view on my life, my "horizontal" efforts too — to be meaningful for others, to do good for others, to bring repair and blessing to the world — take on, within my existential experience and my framework of thought, a depth and weight that would be absent from a world that is only "horizontal." See also the following note.

10. Does religion call upon a person to devote himself solely to the vertical bond, and to become estranged from his social-horizontal bond? In its fundamentalist interpretation, and also in a small part of the classical traditional streams, one can find such a tone, in which, through a sharp

opposition between the earthly and the heavenly, the entire social sphere is placed within the former domain, and whoever seeks a life of spirit and devotion must set himself apart not only from the physiological pleasures of this world but also from the public. But in my view, a religious position that disregards the human other and removes him from the religious "story" quickly turns into an irresponsible, immoral, and even fanatical and violent conception. I believe that the Jewish position on this matter is that the two dimensions, the vertical and the horizontal, together constitute the value-based picture of the world, complementing and balancing one another. Moreover, the Jewish solution is that the vertical axis, of all things, most affirms the importance of the horizontal plane, since the most significant revelation of God in the world is the image of God within man. The fact that I myself was created in the image of God makes me the entity responsible for what occurs in our world, and leads to an obligation to do justice and righteousness in the land. Conversely, the fact that my other, too, was created in the image of God leads me to the values of human dignity, equality and love of one's fellow creatures, and to the conception that the realization of these is the core of the service of God — "that which is hateful to you, do not do to your fellow; this is the whole Torah, and the rest is commentary" (Shabbat 31a). This fact can also reframe the individual's dependence on his human-social fabric, the essential existential importance of the voice of the other, to the point that it echoes within me and I am forever penetrated by it from end to end, as discussed in the body of the essay — for the other is not merely one more person like me, but also a revelation of a special and unique divine hue, which, to some degree, stitches the horizontal and vertical axes together. I hope to write on this at greater length elsewhere. See also: Rav Yuval Sherlo, Be-Tzalmo, Jerusalem, 5769.

11. Bavli, Bava Metzia 10a.